

The River Dragon's Long Sleep

The blossom mountains of Yamato rise in soft green folds above terraced rice fields and little villages strung with paper lanterns, where cherry trees drop their petals on the wind and red torii gates mark the quiet shrines. Mist drifts among the bamboo, the moon lays a silver path on the river, and the hills are full of gentle spirits: a riddling fox, shy fireflies who light the lanterns, a jolly trickster tanuki, stone guardian dogs, and a great old river dragon who brings the rains. Here a hero is not the strongest or the loudest, but the one who is patient, thinks things through, and is kind to every living thing. The grandest deeds are done with wisdom and courage and a gentle heart, and even a fearsome guardian, met with a calm and friendly word, often turns out kinder than it looks.



The River Dragon's Long Sleep

Read aloud, slowly and warmly. Stop often to let the children answer. There are no wrong answers here, only brave new ideas to try.

Before you begin

The Silver River is running low. All summer the rains have not come, and the terraced rice fields are growing thirsty. The grown-ups in the village look up at the dry blue sky and shake their heads.

Far up the mountain sleeps the Gentle River Dragon. When he stirs, the rains come. But he has slept far, far too long this time, and the river keeps sinking.

Granny Yuki the Tale-Keeper calls you to her side. "You two have clever heads and kind hearts," she says. "Will you climb over the mountain and wake him, gently, before the harvest fails?"

She gives you three gifts: a little bronze bell, a ball of red thread, and a sweet rice cake. Then she smiles. "Up there we do not win by being the strongest. We win by being wise, brave, and kind."

What is your hero name? Are you a hero of Wisdom, of Courage, or of Kindness?

Stop 1: The Guardian Gate

You climb the steep path and come to the Red Torii Gate. On each side sits a big stone lion-dog, still as rock. As you step close, they blink and stretch.

"None may pass," they rumble, "until you answer our riddle." They look fierce, but their eyes are kind. They like a good thinking face, and a brave guess is welcome.

What could you do? Could you listen closely and puzzle it out together? You could ask Kon the Fox for a hint. A thoughtful guess is allowed too. What do you try?

When you answer, the Guardian Lion-Dogs nod and lean back. "Well thought," they say. The gate swings open, and the path leads on.

Stop 2: The Moonlit Bridge

Night is falling now. Ahead, an old wooden bridge arches over the river, silver in the moonlight. It looks lovely, but it sways and creaks when you hurry.

You can feel it. This bridge only holds firm for those who cross it slowly and calmly, together, with a steady heart.

How will you cross? Could you go gently, hand in hand, taking a deep breath? Could you tie the red thread so you stay together? What is your plan?

When you cross slowly and calmly, side by side, the bridge holds firm under your feet. You step off the far end, safe, into the misty dark.

Stop 3: The Sleeping Dragon

At last you reach the wide, misty river. And there he is: the great River Dragon, curled along the water, vast as a hill, breathing slow. He has slept for so long that mist has gathered on his back.

This is not a fight. You could never wake such a giant by shouting, and you would not want to frighten him. He is gentle, and a little bit lonely.

What kind, calm thing could you do? You have a little bell that rings soft and clear. You could ring it and sing him a quiet, friendly song. What do you try?

When you ring the little bell and sing softly, the great dragon's sleepy eyes open. "Someone came," he murmurs, surprised and glad. "Someone came to wake me kindly."

The Rains Return

The River Dragon uncurls and rises, slow and grand, into the night sky. He winds above you like a long blue ribbon, and where he passes, soft rain begins to fall.

The Silver River brims and shines. Down in the valley, the thirsty rice fields drink deep and turn green again. The dragon is not lonely now, for he has friends.

High above, Amaterasu the Sun-Kami breaks through the clouds and smiles down on you. You did it together. You were wise, you were brave, and most of all, you were kind. Well done, heroes.

The Story in Pictures



Two heroes thinking before a tall red torii gate guarded by two friendly stone lion-dogs with kind faces, blossom and moonlight around.



Two heroes crossing a gracefully arched wooden bridge over a wide river silver in the moonlight, stepping gently together.



Two heroes gently ringing a little bell beside a great gentle river dragon curled asleep among misty water, beginning to stir.



A great gentle river dragon awake and rising into a dawn sky as soft rain falls, the river
brimming and green rice fields drinking, two heroes cheering below.

My Adventure Sheet

Draw your hero

My name

I am a hero of

My energy stars (colour one in when you spend it)



My magics



My magic is

It can



My magic is

It can



My magic is

It can

What I carry

Notes

Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.

Wits and Wonder

Story Pack

<https://github.com/agigante80/wits-and-wonder>

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